NCR COMPUTRONIC

Operator's Manual

Version 0.1

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The author of this work has no relationship with The National Cash Register Company (NCR). This material was intuited from reading manuals for similar NCR machines from the era and from hands-on experience with an actual NCR Computronic by David Lovett a.k.a Usagi Electric.

Table of Contents

1 Introduction....1
2 Keyboard....2
2.1 Release Key....2
2.2 Amount Keyboard....2
2.3 Date Selection....3
2.4 Descriptive Keys....3
2.5 Motor Bars....4
2.6 Typewriter Keyboard....5
2.7 Other Keys and Controls....5
3 Revision History....8
4 References....8

1 Introduction

TODO: Blah, Blah, Blah

2 Keyboard

2.1 Release Key

The "Release" key on the left of the keyboard releases depressed digit and control keys.

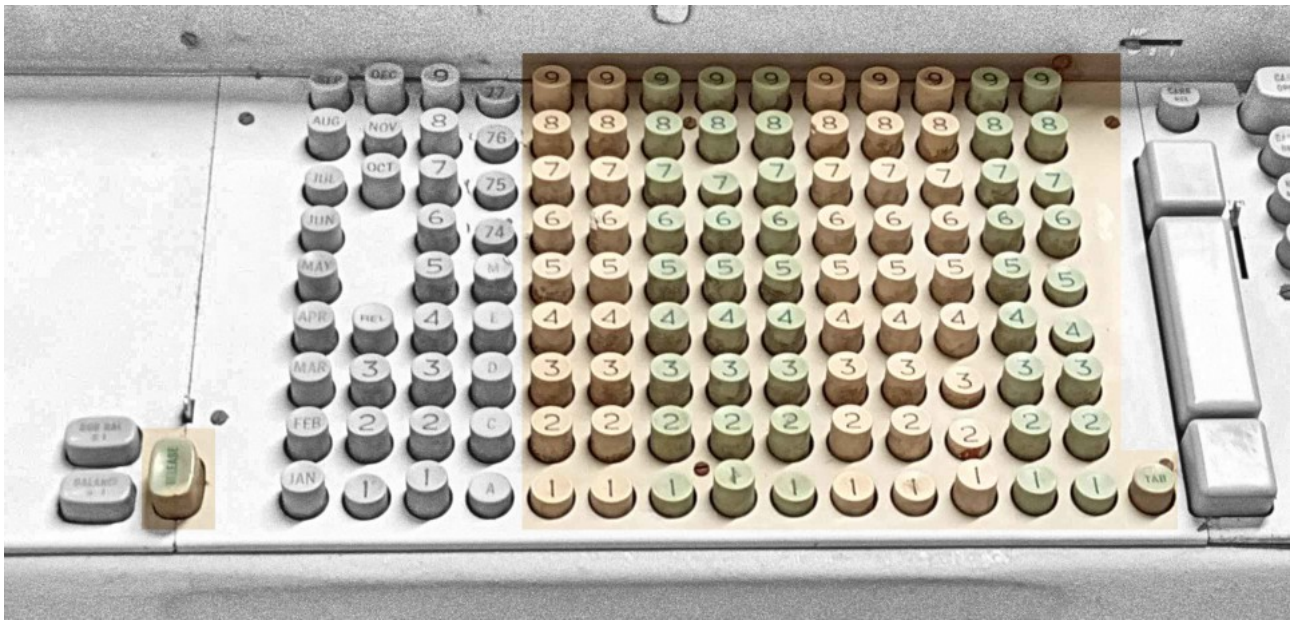
2.2 Amount Keyboard

The digit entry keys are used to enter numeric amounts during computations. Up to 10 digits may be entered. For currency amounts, the first 8 columns are for dollars and the final 2 columns for cents.

Press the large "Release" key on the left of the keyboard to set all of the digits to zero. Then depress digits 1 to 9 in each column to enter the desired number. The number will be printed and the operation for the column will be taken when a motor bar key is pressed.

If you press the wrong digit in a column, say a 2 instead of a 3, then press the new digit and the previous one will pop up. Partial depression of a digit key will release the current digit but not select the new digit; this can be used to set a digit back to zero.

The TAB key on the bottom-right moves forward to the next tab-stop.



2.3 Date Selection

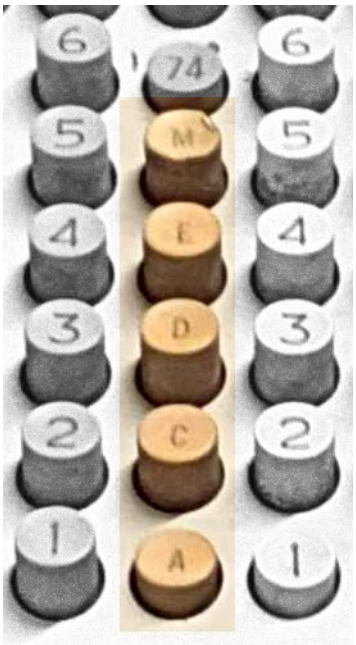
The date selection keys are used to set the current date when entering transactions on the machine. The month, day, and year may be selected for printing in date fields.

The small REL key releases the day keys for entering a new day number.

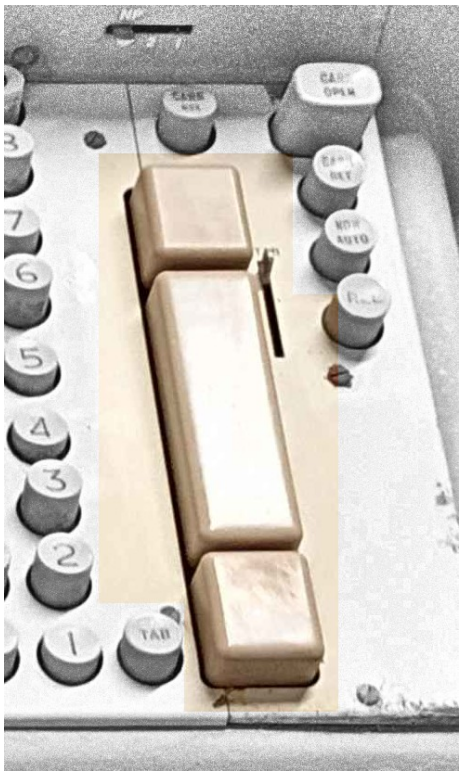
2.4 Descriptive Keys

The M, E, D, C, and A keys may be used to describe the current entry. The operator decides what they mean based on the application, for example D might mean "discount" and C might mean "cash".

TBD: The NCR 400 uses the M and C keys for "pre-programmed factors" like "per 1000" and "per 100". So these may not be descriptive keys. Unclear.



2.5 Motor Bars



TBD: This is based on the NCR 400 description. It needs to be verified against the Computronic.

TBD: NCR 160 has plus and minus keys in this location that look similar.

The three motor bars cause the machine to operate and provide carriage tabulation control as follows:

Upper Motor Bar: A touch operation spaces paper vertically without carriage movement. A hold operation causes vertical spacing and returns the carriage to a predetermined position.

Middle Motor Bar: A touch or hold operation causes carriage tabulation to the next tab-stop.

Lower Motor Bar: A touch operation causes forward skip tabulation to a predetermined position, through any intervening positions. A hold operation causes forward carriage tabulation to a further predetermined position.

Motor Bar Control Lever: Located to the right of the motor bars. Normal operation occurs in the upper position. Disables tabulation in the lower position and spaces the platen vertically.

2.6 Typewriter Keyboard

The typewriter keyboard allows typing alphanumeric information. The space bar, shift key, and backspace key operate in the same manner as a conventional typewriter. Use capital-I for one and capital-O for zero.

The TAB key moves forward to the next tab-stop. The VERT key moves the platen up by one line.

The three return keys RET1, RET2, and RET3 permit operator control of carriage return to three predetermined positions. (TBD: How to set the predetermined positions?)

2.7 Other Keys and Controls

Carriage Release

With the power off, depression of this key permits free manual movement of the carriage in either direction. With power on, a partial depression moves the carriage forward. A full depression moves the carriage in reverse. Carriage halts when the key is released.

Carriage Open

With power on, opens a closed carriage or closes an open carriage. Note that the typewriter keys are inoperative when the carriage is open.

Carriage Return

Returns the carriage to the first tab-stop with carriage control. If the stop has automatic release, the machine operates.

Non Auto Key

Disables automatic operation of the machine. To release this mode, press the system release key.

System Release Key

Restores the Non Auto key and releases item counter reset wheels.

TBD: Reverse key to reverse the last transaction ???

TBD: ???

TBD: ???

TBD: ???

TBD: ???

TBD: ???

TBD: ???

TBD: ???

TBD: ???

TBD: ???

3 Revision History

0.1	March 2026	Rhys Weatherley	Initial version describing the keyboard

4 References

NCR 160 Bookkeeping Machine Operator's Manual, The National Cash Register Company, https://bitsavers.org/pdf/ncr/bookkeeping/NCR_160_Bookkeeping_Machine_Operators_Manual.pdf

NCR 400 Electronic Accounting Machine Operating Instructions, The National Cash Register Company, https://bitsavers.org/pdf/ncr/bookkeeping/ST3400_NCR_400_Operating_Instructions_Jan68.pdf